IGOs can be classified according to the scope of their memberships and their purpose. On the one hand, there are universal political organizations such as the erstwhile League of Nations and the present day United Nations and its specialized agencies which endeavour to include international membership as far as possible. On the other hand, there can be several regional groupings of states or even groupings based on some specific or general purposes and, therefore, the membership is also regional and sometimes specific. They might be performing political, economic, developmental, military, socio-cultural or other functions for their member states. The most prominent of these kinds of IGOs are the North Atlantic treaty Organization (NATO), the Organization of American States (OAS), the Organization of African Unity (OAU), the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC), Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), the Arab League, Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) and, the most notable one the European Union. To mention a few others, IGOs which are concerned with social or developmental matters, are the World Health Organization (WHO), the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the International Labour Organization (ILO) and the World Bank.

The number of IGOs increased between the period of 1945–1985 with a post-World War II high of 378 but, by 1990, the number has declined to around 300 IGOs. Nevertheless, IGOs are considered as crucial actors in international relations because their policy and behaviour have definite impact on the foreign policy of their members and also on the non-members. Most often, sending representatives to the IGOs or funding the IGOs or interacting with other states through the IGOs leads the statesmen to believe that IGOs are behaving like international actors and must be given importance in their foreign policy considerations.[26]

Inter-State Non-Governmental Actors

Inter-state non-governmental or non-territorial transnational organizations have also found prominence in international relations because of the kind of impact they have on the political, economic and socio-cultural life of states. They can be categorized into two types—religious and economic.